EXTREME OWNERSHIP

Moderator Guide | Ranger Mastery Program - Day 1

A conversation about responsibility, teamwork, and customer outcomes.

Audience: Support Engineers, Rangers, Escalation Engineers, Technical Leads

Suggested duration: 90 minutes | 6-10 participants
Conversation only | No written activities

1. Top learnings and conversation purpose

RMP Day 1 | Week 1: Mindset. Explore ownership in support, inspired by the RMP study guide summarizing *Extreme Ownership* by Jocko Willink and Leif Babin.

Learning objectives - through conversation, participants will:

- **Own the contribution:** distinguish taking responsibility for the next useful action from blame, unlimited control, or doing everything alone.
- **Stay open to feedback:** explore how ego, mistakes, and unclear intent influence support decisions.
- **Align on the outcome:** connect simple priorities and clear responsibilities to the customer's actual need.
- **Work across boundaries:** consider how to coordinate dependencies, escalate obstacles, and confirm accepted ownership.
- **Balance initiative and authority:** discuss when to act, ask for help, or seek a decision without bypassing safeguards.

Expected outcome

Participants leave with a shared view of ownership as constructive action and transparent coordination, not self-blame or constant availability. They hear how ownership looks across roles and regions and identify practical ways to preserve customer continuity while respecting authority and capacity. There are **no written tasks, simulations, worksheets, tests, or required follow-up assignments**.

Suggested 90-minute conversation

Time	Conversation topic	Question at its heart
0-8	Welcome, objectives, and opening round	Where does this show up in our support work?
8-20	1. Own the next useful contribution	What does ownership look like when you cannot directly fix the customer's problem?
20-32	2. Ego, mistakes, and feedback	What makes it easier or harder to acknowledge that our approach needs to change?
32-44	3. Shared purpose before instructions	How do we know that several teams are working toward the same outcome rather than just completing their assigned tasks?
44-56	4. Simple priorities under pressure	What makes a support plan simple enough that everyone can explain the next priority?
56-68	5. Shared ownership across teams	What helps a case feel jointly supported rather than passed from queue to queue?
68-80	6. Initiative, limits, and escalation	When is taking initiative the right response, and when is asking for a decision the most responsible action?
80-90	Key takeaways and lessons learned	What changed or expanded our thinking?

Use: a flexible route, not a questionnaire to finish. Open with one question and choose follow-ups as needed. Examples are conversation starters, not exercises. The six topics are original support adaptations, not a claimed sequence from the source.

2. Conversation: responsibility and humility

Topic 1 | Own the next useful contribution - 8-20 min

Learning objective: Separate responsibility from blame and unlimited personal control.

Open the conversation: *"What does ownership look like when you cannot directly fix the customer's problem?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What can we influence even when another team owns the product or decision?
- When does taking ownership become taking on work we lack capacity or authority to do?
- How can we name a dependency honestly without using it as an excuse?

If a concrete example helps: A product fix is pending elsewhere and the customer has heard nothing. Ask: *What can the support engineer still own: the question to the product team, the update, or clarity about the blocker?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Rather than deciding who is at fault, what contribution could move the customer situation forward?"*

Learning point to draw out: Ownership means making your contribution clear and acting on it. It does not mean personally controlling every dependency or absorbing every failure.

Topic 2 | Ego, mistakes, and feedback - 20-32 min

Learning objective: Explore how openness supports correction and trust.

Open the conversation: *"What makes it easier or harder to acknowledge that our approach needs to change?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What happens when we defend an early theory because we have already invested effort in it?
- What does useful feedback sound like between a senior and a newer engineer?
- How can a lead acknowledge a mistake without turning it into self-criticism or blame?

If a concrete example helps: A colleague finds evidence against the case owner's preferred diagnosis. Ask: *What response would keep the evidence and customer outcome ahead of personal credibility?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us focus on the response to feedback, not label an individual as having an ego."*

Learning point to draw out: Accountability becomes useful when it leads to correction, learning, and a visible next action rather than defensiveness or public blame.

3. Conversation: purpose and priorities

Topic 3 | Shared purpose before instructions - 32-44 min

Learning objective: Connect the team's work with a clear customer outcome.

Open the conversation: *"How do we know that several teams are working toward the same outcome rather than just completing their assigned tasks?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What context helps an engineer understand why a request matters?
- When should we ask for clarification instead of following an unclear instruction?
- How could customer impact change how we interpret a technically complete handoff?

If a concrete example helps: One team considers the diagnostic collection complete; another still cannot decide a mitigation. Ask: *What shared purpose or missing decision would help connect their work?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Before comparing team procedures, what customer outcome are we trying to achieve together?"*

Learning point to draw out: Clear intent lets people make better local decisions. Completing an activity is not always the same as achieving the needed outcome.

Topic 4 | Simple priorities under pressure - 44-56 min

Learning objective: Explore clarity about what matters next without ignoring other commitments.

Open the conversation: *"What makes a support plan simple enough that everyone can explain the next priority?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What happens when five actions are all presented as the top priority?
- Who needs to know when a new incident changes existing commitments?
- What would cause us to reassess rather than keep following the original plan?

If a concrete example helps: A critical escalation arrives while evidence collection and customer updates are due on other cases. Ask: *How could the lead clarify priorities, route work, and reset commitments without silently dropping them?*

If the discussion drifts: *"We do not need a universal ranking. What information and communication would make this priority decision clear?"*

Learning point to draw out: A simple plan names the immediate priority, responsibilities, dependencies, and a review point. Local severity rules and customer risk still govern.

4. Conversation: teamwork and authority

Topic 5 | Shared ownership across teams - 56-68 min

Learning objective: Discuss coordination without blurred accountability.

Open the conversation: *"What helps a case feel jointly supported rather than passed from queue to queue?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What makes an internal request actionable for the receiving team?
- How do we keep responsibility clear while helping beyond our own queue?
- What should happen if the next team has not accepted the transfer?

If a concrete example helps: Two regions each believe the other owns the next customer update. Ask: *What explicit acceptance or read-back would protect continuity for both teams and the customer?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Instead of comparing regions, what agreement would remove the ownership gap?"*

Learning point to draw out: Helping across boundaries does not mean leaving ownership implicit. Context, accepted responsibilities, and timely escalation support a shared outcome.

Topic 6 | Initiative, limits, and escalation - 68-80 min

Learning objective: Balance responsible autonomy with authority and safety.

Open the conversation: *"When is taking initiative the right response, and when is asking for a decision the most responsible action?"*

Follow the conversation:

- What can an engineer decide locally, and what needs approval?
- How can we escalate a blocker with a clear recommendation rather than simply forward the problem?
- Which recurring constraints require a manager's action instead of more personal effort?

If a concrete example helps: An engineer believes a production change may help but lacks authorization. Ask: *What would ownership look like without bypassing the required review or staying indefinitely online?*

If the discussion drifts: *"Let us distinguish being proactive from taking an unapproved risk or making an unlimited commitment."*

Learning point to draw out: Ownership includes surfacing constraints, seeking the right decision, and preserving safe continuity. It does not override change controls, staffing needs, or off-duty boundaries.

5. Moderator's guide: keep it a conversation

Set the tone: opening eight minutes

Introduce the objectives and expected outcome. Say: *"This is a conversation, not an assessment. Different roles and regions will see this differently. Use fictional or anonymized work patterns, not customer details. You can pass, and I will make room for each voice."*

Use a short opening round: *"Where do you most often see a gap between owning a task and owning the customer outcome? A phrase or short example is enough."* Invite everyone once, allowing about 20-30 seconds each. Do not solve each case. Name one or two shared themes, then move to Topic 1.

Make participation broad, not forced

Aim for **6-10 participants**. With a larger group, use more round tables or allow more time. Rotate the first voice, invite different roles and shifts, and allow silence for thought. Everyone receives a genuine invitation, not an obligation to disclose or defend their ability.

What you notice	A useful moderator phrase
The same people answer first	"Thank you. Before adding more, let us hear from someone who has not spoken on this topic."
A quieter participant has not had space	"Would you like to add a view from your role or shift? Passing is completely fine."
A speaker runs long	"Let me pause there to make room for others. What is the main point you would like us to take from that?"
The conversation becomes a detailed case review	"We do not need to resolve the old case. What responsibility, dependency, or ownership gap does it illustrate?"
A person or region is blamed	"Let us examine the work conditions and behaviors, not judge the person or team. What would help any engineer here?"
Participants disagree	"What could each team reasonably influence, and what shared agreement would help?"
Discussion moves to an unrelated issue	"That matters, but it takes us away from today's objective. Can we connect it to this question, or leave it for the appropriate channel?"
There is silence	"Take a moment. Would the fictional support example help? What might be difficult in that situation?"

Bridge between topics

Reflect neutrally: *"I am hearing [theme], with a different experience around [difference]. Have I understood? That connects to our next question about [next topic]."* Do not manufacture agreement. Skip optional follow-ups if time is short rather than rush the closing round.

Boundaries: arrange live-queue coverage and follow normal incident and safety procedures. No customer identifiers, raw logs, credentials, personal health disclosures, or live technical changes. Acknowledge sensitive personal concerns and offer the appropriate private support route; do not investigate them in the round table.

6. Close: key takeaways and lessons learned

Key takeaways to connect back to the objectives

- **Own your contribution, not every variable.** Move the situation forward without turning responsibility into self-blame.
- **Put the outcome ahead of ego.** Make room for evidence, feedback, and course correction.
- **Keep intent and priorities clear.** Explain why the next action matters and what commitments change.
- **Coordinate explicitly.** Shared effort still needs accepted ownership and realistic capacity.
- **Initiative has safeguards.** Escalating a constraint can be the responsible next action.

Lessons-learned conversation: minutes 80-87

Invite a brief closing round, with the option to pass: *"What is one idea you are taking away, or one colleague's perspective that changed or expanded your thinking?"* Keep contributions short so everyone has space. No writing or public commitment is required.

If helpful, ask: *"Where might this help in daily support work?"* or *"What still needs team or leadership support?"* Reflect actual participant insights, not anticipated outcomes.

Examples to help the moderator recognize learning

A participant might say...	Connection to the learning objective
"I cannot control the fix, but I can own the next update."	Contribution: distinguish an external dependency from a responsibility you can still fulfill.
"A transfer message did not mean the next owner accepted."	Teamwork: confirm who owns the next decision and commitment.
"Asking for approval is not avoiding ownership."	Authority: move work forward without bypassing required safeguards.

Moderator wrap-up: minutes 87-90

Summarize two or three themes heard, acknowledge differences, and return to the objectives. Do not promise actions you cannot authorize.

Closing thought: *"Ownership is not doing everything yourself. It is making your contribution, constraints, and next commitments clear enough that the customer is not left in the gap."*

Source and adaptation note

Based on the RMP *Extreme Ownership - Study Guide & Training Summary*, summarizing the book by Jocko Willink and Leif Babin. Contents and selected introductory/theme sections reviewed November 2, 2026; the full book and linked TEDx talk were not reviewed. Questions and examples here are original support adaptations, not reproduced book material or an official author guide.

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